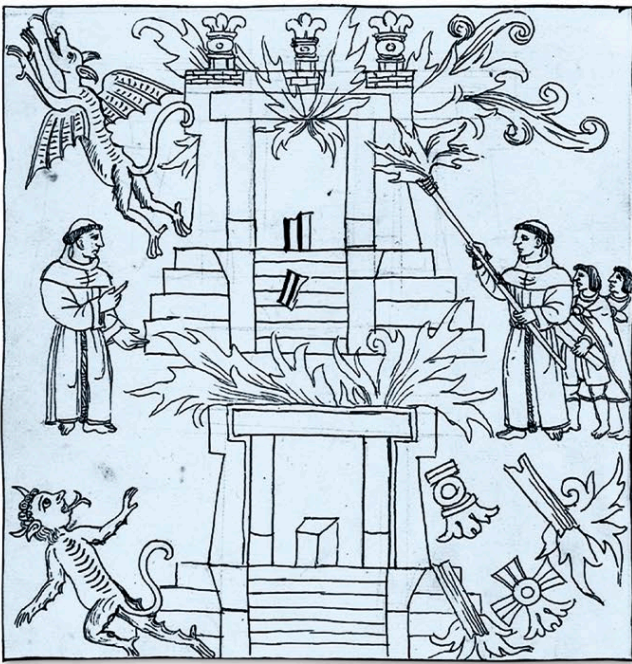




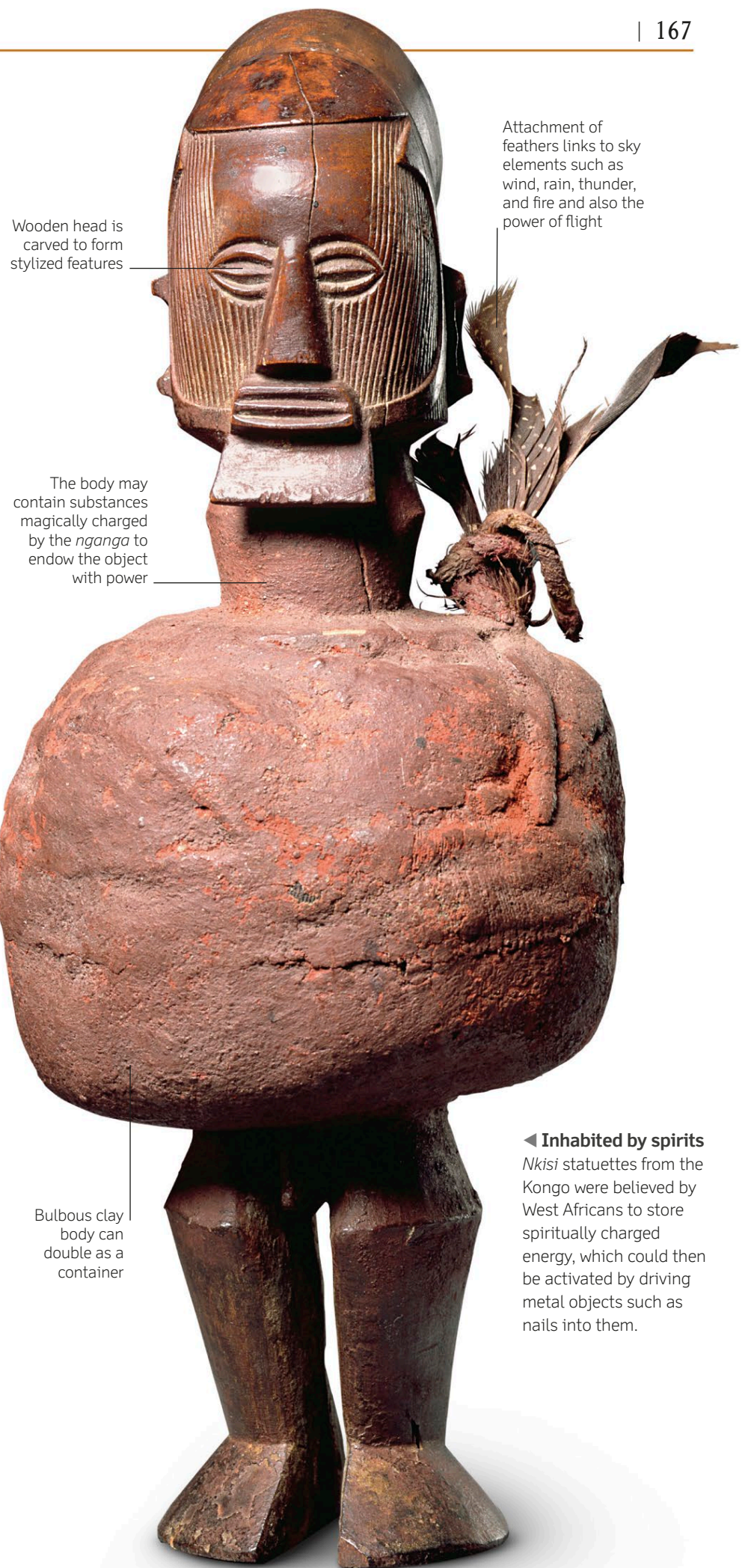
▲ Fanatical fires

This illustration from the *Historia de Tlaxcala* shows Spanish friars burning down an Aztec temple. The demonic figures who are depicted fleeing the inferno underline the Spanish view that native temples were centers of devil worship.

violent eruptions of persecution and massacre—Franciscan friar Diego de Landa tortured 158 suspected Mayan magicians to death in 1562, for instance—native religious practices persisted. Local people continued to consult *tonalpouhque* (diviners), who could tell a person's fortune from the date on the 260-day sacred calendar on which they were born; those who used hallucinogens to enter the spirit world; and also *curanderos* (folk healers). In time, saints and their images became mixed with traditional deities and veneration continues in this form today.

Native North American practices

Similar misunderstandings arose in North America. For example, local medicine men and healers were confused with Navajo skin-walkers—men believed to have attained deep spiritual knowledge, which they chose to use for evil by taking on animal forms—by Europeans who indiscriminately labeled all their actions as black magic. The Native American sense of spiritual oneness in the world, in which each creature or plant had its own spirit, was also misconstrued by Europeans who thought locals literally prayed to trees, rocks, and animals.



Wooden head is carved to form stylized features

Attachment of feathers links to sky elements such as wind, rain, thunder, and fire and also the power of flight

The body may contain substances magically charged by the *nganga* to endow the object with power

Bulbous clay body can double as a container

◀ Inhabited by spirits

Nkisi statuettes from the Kongo were believed by West Africans to store spiritually charged energy, which could then be activated by driving metal objects such as nails into them.